the original documents/ infrastructure, some irregularities were corrected.

The five key parameters of evaluation were Learning Experience, Living Experience, Selection Process, Placement Performance and Future Orientation (see *box*). The scores of these parameters were then summed up to get the total objective score of each institute. The final rank was assigned to B-schools based on objective data after various levels of cross-validation through multiple sources and physical audits.

To reflect India's regional diversity and students' preferences, the overall rankings were used to create separate zonal, parameter-wise and return on investment (RoI) rankings. A Top Emerging MBA Courses list recognises newer institutions whose first batch graduated after 2015. This year also introduces the Most Improved B-schools category, highlighting institutions that have made significant gains in the ITG-MDRA rankings over the past five years. The B-school with the highest percentage improvement in rank over the five-year period tops the list, followed by others in descending order of improvement.

Executive Programmes: Indian B-schools offer an enormous variety of executive programmes—ranging from entry-level options to courses designed for leaders with 15+ years of experience. They differ widely in focus (general management, industry-specific or functional specialisations), curriculum, pedagogy, delivery models (hybrid or direct-to-device), faculty quality, alumni access and fees. These programmes do not confer an MBA or equivalent degree.

For this ranking, meant for a broad audience, we considered only long-established, rigorous general management programmes from top institutes. The evaluation was based solely on objective data gathered through secondary research, using parameters such as programme fees, institute reputation, course continuity, weekly interaction load, eligibility criteria, number of online/ offline sessions and overall pedagogy. The top 15 executive programmes were then ranked on this basis.

Advanced Management Programme (AMPs): The AMP rankings are based entirely on objective data from extensive secondary research. Only programmes meant for senior professionals with at least 10 years of work experience were included to maintain relevance and comparability. These AMPs target leaders and strategic decision-makers, and are delivered in blended or fully online formats to suit executive schedules. Most run for 10-12 months, except ISB's Global AMP, which is a five-month programme. The evaluation considered key parameters such as programme fees, duration, delivery mode, faculty strength, institutional reputation, eligibility criteria, course continuity, alumni profile and overall programme design. Together, these metrics provided a comprehensive and balanced assessment of India's leading AMPs.

Online MBAs: The Online MBA rankings are based solely on objective data from secondary research. Only two-year online or blended programmes from recognised B-schools—leading to a valid master's or postgraduate degree/diploma—were included. Though institutions market them as Executive MBA, Online MBA or Online PGDM, these programmes share a common goal: offering an MBA-equivalent qualification without requiring learners to leave their jobs. Unlike AMPs, they cater to a broader audience, with work-experience requirements varying across schools. The evaluation drew on parameters such as programme fees, campus immersion, degree recognition, eligibility norms, faculty quality, institutional reputation, class frequency and duration, course continuity, alumni engagement, placement outcomes and delivery mode. This framework ensured a rigorous assessment of academic quality, credibility, delivery effectiveness and career impact.

PARAMETER	WEIGHT
LEARNING EXPERIENCE	250
PLACEMENT PERFORMANCE	250
FUTURE ORIENTATION	200
SELECTION PROCESS, GOVERNANCE AND ESTABLISHMENT	150
LIVING EXPERIENCE	150
TOTAL	1,000

Executive Fellow Programmes in Management (EFPMs): The Executive FPM rankings were derived entirely from objective, verified secondary data. Key parameters included programme fees, PhD equivalence and recognition, entrance requirements, work-experience norms, institutional reputation, alumni strength, faculty quality, research output (scholars enrolled and graduated), and research/ consultancy projects over the past three years. This framework enabled a balanced assessment of academic rigour, research depth, faculty capability and institutional strength. These programmes—commonly called Executive FPMs but also offered as Executive Doctoral Programmes or PhDs for Working Professionals—are all PhD-equivalent. They require at least a master's degree with relevant work experience, run for 3 to 6 years, and are delivered in blended or online formats to suit working executives.

Fellow Programmes in Management (FPMs)/ PhD in Management: The FPM/ PhD rankings were developed entirely through secondary research using credible public sources, including institute websites, admission brochures, annual reports and official notifications. Programmes were evaluated across a broad set of academic and research parameters: programme fees, eligibility norms, required entrance exams (CAT, GMAT, GRE, UGC-NET etc.), and stipend structures across Slabs I-III. Additional benefits—HRA (with/ without family), computer and contingency allowances, and domestic/ international conference support—were also assessed.

Research strength was measured through the number of scholars currently enrolled and graduated (up to 2023-24), sponsored and consultancy projects and their funding amounts, and total faculty strength. Institutional reputation was captured through the latest Business Today B-School ranking. All indicators were normalised and weighted to create a composite score, ensuring a transparent, balanced, and data-driven evaluation of India's leading FPM/ PhD programmes in management.

A large team comprising researchers, statisticians, econometricians and analysts worked on this project from April 2026 to September 2026. The MDRA core team, led by Abhishek Agrawal (CEO), comprised Abnish Jha (Senior Project Director), Vaibhav Gupta (Research Manager), Manveer Singh (Assistant Manager EDP), Robin Singh (Research Executive) and Rishav Sharma (Research Executive). ■